The Mihai Eminescu Trust

www.mihaieminescutrust.org

Newsletter and highlights of 2003

This has been our most productive year to date. British conservation trainers' visits have had unparalleled success and 63 buildings have been restored this season. Our organic agricultural activities have expanded; local sales have begun with promising results. Grants for micro-enterprises have been set in motion. We have completed several village surveys recording information on population, buildings, employment and history. The value of our work is increasingly recognised both locally and internationally: we are collaborating with the Romanian Government, councillors, charities and individuals on an unprecedented scale - all with the aspiration that the example of the Whole Village Project will take hold in more of the 230 villages of Saxon Transylvania. Our immense gratitude goes to the Packard Humanities Institute for its constant support of our projects.

VILLAGE ENTERPRISE

- Our organic orchard is thriving. We have a bumper crop of apples this season. Tons of these have already been sold. Over the year, we will be selling organic apple juice in restaurants, bars, stores and hotels. Next year we would hope to expand on this.
- We have established an SRL (Romanian Limited Company) to show, by example, how organic agriculture can be profitable. It is called Pro MET SRL, its statute determines that all profits will go to fund MET charitable work.
- In our house in Biertan central square, we have researched, developed and installed a ground-breaking sewage system that emits pure water. We hope this will act as a working example for domestic sewage systems in the area.
- The Trust has aided Developing Technologies and Imperial College, London to carry out onsite testing in Romania of a horse-drawn hay rake and tedder manufactured by students. The perfected instrument will help the region enhance an organic, sustainable cash crop.



ROADES

- The Trust has given a grant for tools for a carpenter's workshop in the Bunesti commune.
- We have sent over by lorry a large consignment of workmen's tools to the villages to the value of £2,500.
- A census on the Village of Viscri shows that over 200 (50%) of its inhabitants are now actively benefiting from the kaleidoscope of the Trust's work; handicrafts, training, materials, guesthouse tourism, textiles or seed funding
- In Malancrav, a half-completed census reveals a similar picture.

CONSERVATION BUILDING



CLOASTERF

- Ian Pritchett, who runs a conservation building practice near Reading, visited Romania in February with MET Trustees to plan the monthly training programme for the season ahead. We are so grateful for Ian's time, given free of charge. Already he is preparing for 2004.
- Five British experts arrived for a week in March in Romania to give working seminars to 46 new

Romanian trainees on masonry, lime mortar and carpentry on buildings in our villages. Trainers' visits continued each month until October. The training will start again in April 2004.

- By the end of the season – 15th October – we completed restoration work on 63 buildings in the Viscri and Malancrav communes – a huge achievement which breaks all records from previous years.
- A special thanks must go to master stone mason Henry Rumbold. During the last 25 years, he has been responsible for the workmanship carried out on the most important ancient monuments between Berwick and South Yorkshire and has made an outstanding contribution to British heritage. His enthusiasm and generosity and inspired dedication led him to volunteer for three of this season's training sessions in Romania. He has promised to return next year.
- Our trainers and builders continue to help Pro Patrimonio with their Viscri house.



- Marianne Suhr, the universally respected scholar of the Society for the Protection of Ancient Buildings and recent BBC TV star, visited Romania to complete for the MET a practical Conservation Guide (based on MET philosophy) for those engaged in Transylvanian restoration.
- We gave a donation to the German Journeymens' Guild house in Sibiu, enabling 15 men to work in towns and villages of Transylvania.
- The MET attended the prestigious international INTBAU conference in the village of Laslea. Several people from the Trust gave talks on our conservation programme.
- The MET paid for a survey – invited by and now presented to the World Bank – to rebuild the large 19th century Saxon school house in the village of Crit. This was entirely stripped by the communists in 1945.
- Work has been completed on the restoration of Mesendorf Tanzplatz.

CHURCH RESTORATION

- The Trust finished the first phase of restoring and saving a recently collapsed tower of the fortified Lutheran church of Bunesti.
- Work started in August in the precincts of Apold church. The MET has provided advice from master builders and architects as well as much needed funding.
- Our building team has helped restore part of Viscri Church.
- Five buildings owned by the Lutheran Church, one owned by the Romanian Catholic Church and one owned by the Romanian Orthodox Church have been restored by the Trust in four villages in our two communes.
- The Trust has helped prepare a study for the restoration of Sighisoara's synagogue – a most important part of the citadel's heritage – and is actively seeking funding for this important place of worship.
- A small grant was given to a student from Bucharest Institute of Architecture to complete his study of the UNESCO-listed church in Saschis.

ECO TOURISM

- Several international travel operators have brought tours to Romania on our introduction, and have come to see our restoration work. They are developing tourism plans for the area. We continue to introduce more companies, the most notable recent addition being Abercrombie and Kent.
- Jessica Douglas-Home, gave a talk about Transylvania in the House of Lords to 60 members of the Tourist Industry attended by the Romanian Ambassador.
- Landmark Trust representatives came to Transylvania to see four of the MET's recently restored Saxon houses. This has led to an unprecedented collaboration between the two trusts. At the end of the visit, the British Council generously hosted a dinner.



MALANCRAV

• To promote equestrian tourism, the Trust has given a grant to convert a traditional barn near Tirgu Mures into an agricultural museum.

• We have bought a fourth horse – a beautiful grey – to expand our equestrian tourism capabilities. We have taken several horse tours through the villages this year.



VISCRI

THE MANOR HOUSE

• Tenders for the work on Malancrav Manor came through from three large construction firms. The estimates were unacceptably expensive and involved too much cement. Under the guidance of architect Jan Huelseman and William Blacker, the Trust made the bold but, in the event, excellent decision to use our well-tried local master-builders and local materials. The foundations are now laid, the outer walls built and second stage preparation during the winter is in full flow for the spring season ahead.

• Antique furniture is being bought, and restored, in preparation for the completion of the building. We will continue to look for suitable pieces.



MALANCRAV MANOR

ROMANIAN GOVERNMENT AND INSTITUTIONS

• Prime Minister Nastase visited London and celebrated the Anglo-Romanian Bank's 30th anniversary in Knightsbridge. He congratulated the MET on their work on lobbying for an alternative site than Sighisoara for the Dracula Theme Park.

• The Ministry of Culture has expressed its appreciation of our work on the 38 state-owned buildings which we have restored over the last three years.

• The MET chairman attended the 27th session of UNESCO World Heritage Committee in Paris, and was asked to join forces for a Conservation Zone conference in Sighisoara. A dinner was given by the Hungarian Ambassador, Andre Erdes.

• In September, Bucharest Institute of Architecture held a meeting in the Saxon citadel of Dealul Frumos. The MET has been asked to help set up a Study Centre for Vernacular Architecture here and to supply a conservation trainer to contribute to the Institute's scientific studies.

• The Romanian Minister of Culture visited Viscri in August. Besides seeing the church, he examined MET restored properties and complimented Caroline Fernolend on her work.

• Following our donation to Sighisoara to enter the UN's Agenda 21, the planning stage progresses in monthly meetings with assistance from the MET.

• We have also helped the towns of Medias, Sibiu and Falticeni towards entry into Agenda 21.

• We have received approval from the Ministry of Culture for the restoration of the Samuel Maetz clavichord in Sighisoara's Museum.

IN GENERAL

• The start of 2003 saw the transfer of our central office from Sibiu to Sighisoara – putting our administration at the heart of our activities.

• Our Fauna survey of the Saxon Villages – completed last summer by a Belgian team of scientists – has been widely published by the MET.



• The artist Celia Ward braved the cold and began the first of her many painting visits to Malancrav, where she is immersing herself in one of the MET's villages. We will be helping her with exhibitions in Bucharest and London in 2004.

• In May, fifteen trustees from the Horizon Foundation – who under the enlightened guidance of Jeremy Amos have helped create the Whole Village Project over the last three years – landed in Sibiu. Travelling east, we showed the group our work in the villages. After 4 days, the visit ended

with a delicious working lunch at one of our sheepfolds.

- With sadness we report the death this summer of our patron Hugh Trevor Roper (Lord Dacre), the historian, a true friend to Romanian culture. We welcome our two new patrons, Zac Goldsmith (The Ecologist) and Kim Wilkie (Wilkie Associates).
- The Trust supported a 6th year veterinary student from Iasi University to study in three practices in Norfolk for the month of August.
- The White Cube Gallery in London is holding a photographic exhibition of our villages in the Bunesti commune on 10th December.
- A dinner was held in London for the Malancrav Hungarian Catholic Church, where an Angus McQueen Maramures film (supported by the Trust) was shown.
- Jessica Douglas-Home flew with The Prince of Wales to Bacau, then drove on to Suceava to meet President Iliescu and the British and Romanian Ambassadors at a dinner where the concept and the practical steps necessary for implementing a Conservation Zone were discussed.
- The Prince of Wales played polo near Maidenhead in aid of the MET. We are most grateful for the sum of money raised on this occasion.

PUBLICATIONS

If you would like to buy any of the following publications please contact us on 020 7229 7618.

The Plight of the Saxons of Transylvania
by William Blacker: £5

Guest Houses in Transylvania – and walks among the fortified churches in the area of Medias
by Kilian Dörr: £5

The Saxon Villages of Transylvania
by Kim Wilkie: £10

Once Upon another Time
by Jessica Douglas-Home: £15

Romania: Cross-Road of Cultures
by John Villiers: £5

Fauna Survey of the Saxon Villages of Romania
by Ilf Jacobs and Pieter Blonde: £25

A Study of the buildings in the Saxon Villages of Transylvania: Construction, Tradition and Future Repair
by Marianne Suhr: £25

Searching for Sarmizegetusa
by Caroline Juler: £10

COLLABORATION

Over the last 12 months we have collaborated with the following organisations on work relevant to Transylvania.

Agenda 21
BBC
British Council
British Embassy, Bucharest
Bucharest Institute of Architecture
Bunesti Commune Council
CORONA
FARA
FCE
Fundatia Alba Eglesia
Gaia Heritage
Historic Properties restoration
IJP Building Conservation
Imperial College, London.
INTBAU
Landmark Trust
Laslea Commune Town Hall
Lutheran Church
Messerschmidt Foundation
Ministry of Culture, Bucharest
Ministry of Historic Monuments
NaturAgro SRL
Norwegian Government
President Iliescu's office
Prime Minister Nastase's office
Pro Patrimono
Romanian Cultural Foundation
Romanian Embassy, London.
Rough Guide to Romania
Sighisoara Town Hall
Stefan cel Mare Horse Riding Centre
Stone Federation of Great Britain
Working Horse Association of Romania
SPAB
Stone Federation
The German Journeymen, Sibiu.
The Prince's Trust
UNDP
UNESCO
Various Travel and Tourist Agencies
World Bank, Washington
World Heritage Committee

The Mihai Eminescu Trust Registered charity number: 800590
63 Hillgate Place, London W8 7SS Tel: 020 7229 7618 Fax: 020 7792 9998
Email: met@hana.demon.co.uk Information about staying in our guesthouses: methouses@hana.demon.co.uk